

Evaluating What Matters: Evidence Standards in Crisis Contexts

Workshop: Leveraging Evidence for Effective Anticipatory Action

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The decision makers' dilemma: Each challenge has many potentially good solutions, but time and funding are limited

Are choices based on...



Instincts



Ideology



Inertia



**Search for
silver bullets**

There is a long history of excitement around new innovations to address poverty, climate change, and other social problems

CLEAN COOKSTOVES



ONE LAPTOP PER CHILD



MICROFINANCE



Unfortunately many of these innovations had limited or even negative consequences when scaled up in the field

CLEAN COOKSTOVES

The New York Times

Developing Nations to Get Clean- Burning Stoves

By John M. Broder
September 20, 2010

FINANCIAL TIMES

Carbon credits from cookstoves emissions largely worthless, study finds

By Kenza Bryan
January 23, 2024

ONE LAPTOP PER CHILD

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

A Little Laptop With Big Ambitions

By Steve Stecklow and James Bandler
November 24, 2007

FP

Why did One Laptop Per Child fail?

By Joshua Keating
September 9, 2009

MICROFINANCE

CNN

Microcredit plants seeds of success in Africa

October 25, 2000

Bloomberg

Big Money Backs Tiny Loans That Lead to Debt, Despair and Even Suicide

By Gavin Finch and David
Kocieniewski
May 3, 2022

Is anticipatory action a new “silver bullet”?

Evidence from impact evaluations can help you choose where to deploy your resources for maximum impact



Choose programmes based on **local context** and **global knowledge** of what works

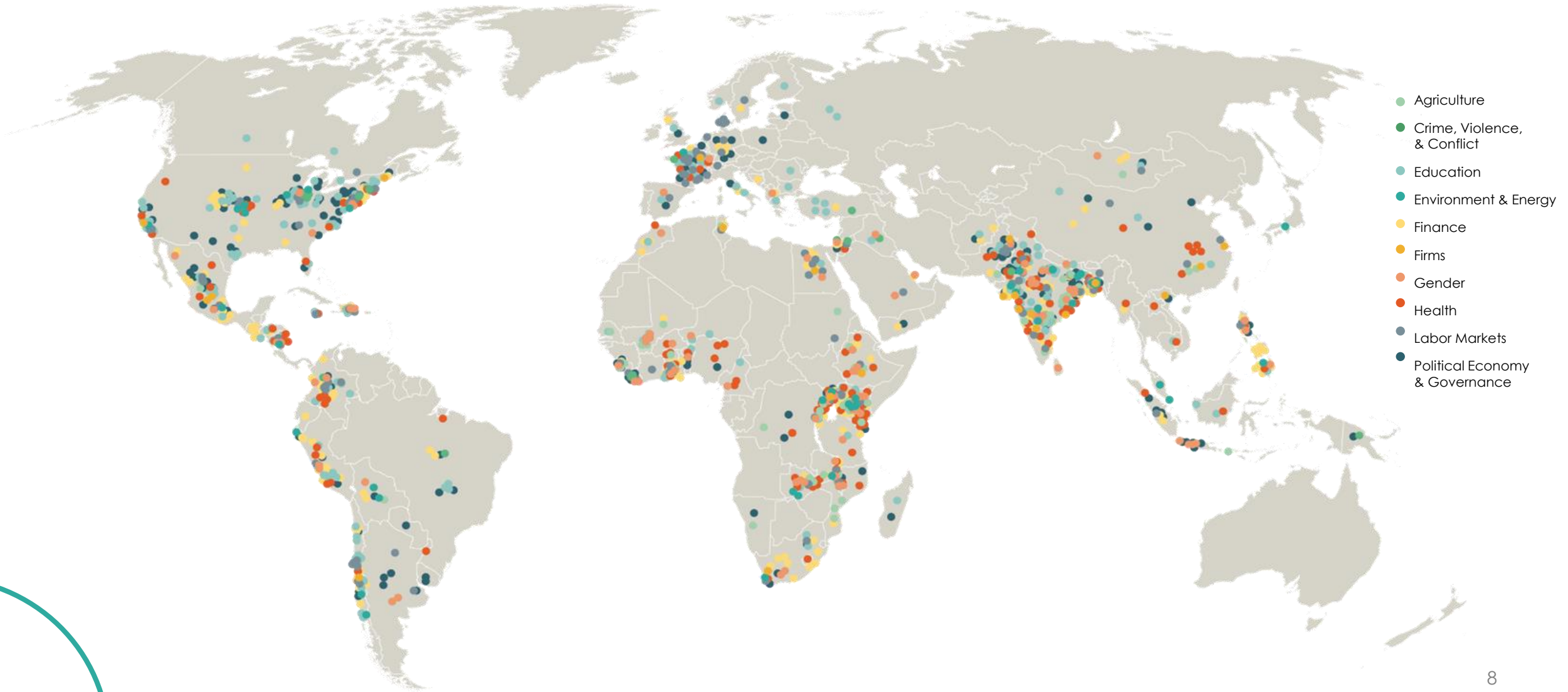


Use **rigorous** impact evaluations (RCTs) to **test**:

- if your program has the intended **impact**
- which **design features** lead to higher impacts

Randomised evaluations offer a **scientific approach** to understanding impacts in development and humanitarian contexts

JPAL researchers have completed 2,300+ randomised evaluations in 121 countries



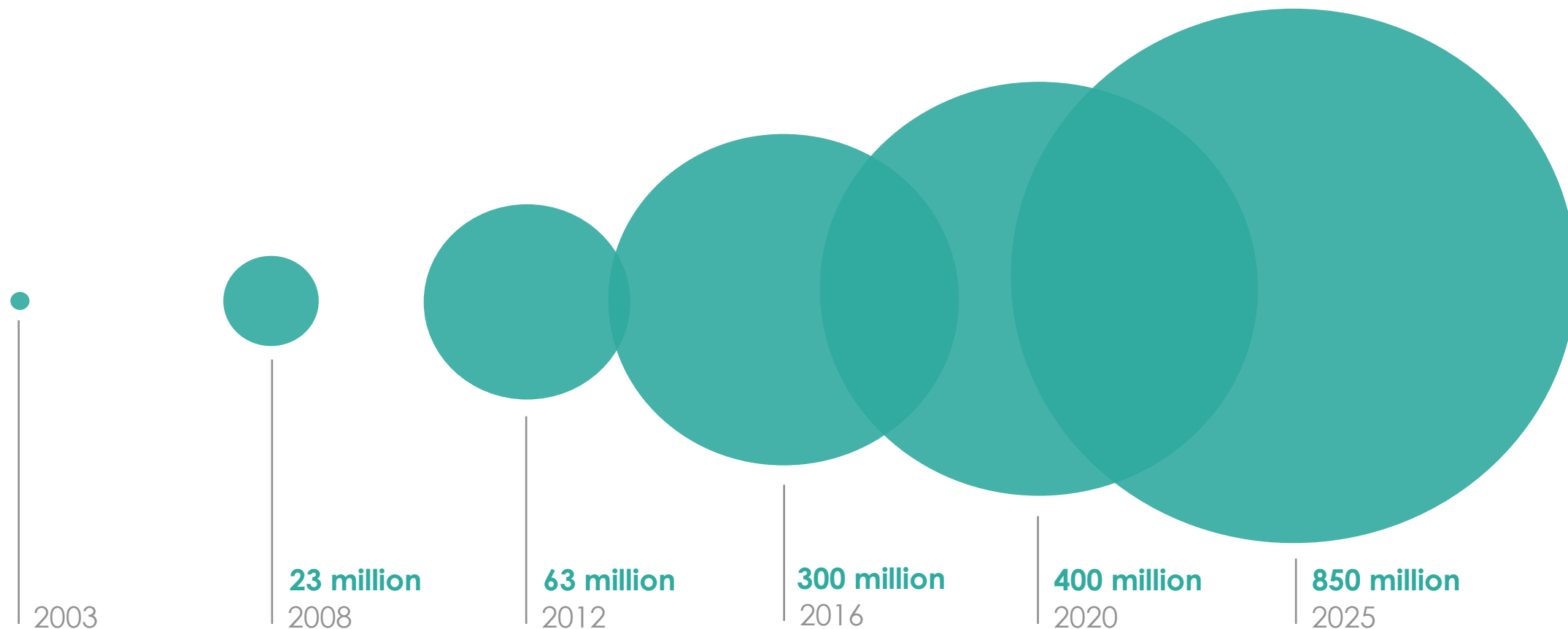
Our approach to randomised evaluation at J-PAL

- We focus our use of randomised evaluations in instances where we believe the results will not only allow us to make important program-level decisions...
- but also extend beyond those programs to teach us more about
 - **human behaviour**,
 - the **mechanisms through which programs** and policies have impact
- and that also allow us to leverage these results to influence programming at scale

We do this in many cases through long-term partnerships with governments and organisations

... and significant progress in the use of rigorous evaluations for programmatic and policy decisions

People reached by programs and policies informed by J-PAL evaluations



Randomised evaluations can
provide rich insight into the mechanisms that
lead to change



As we seek to protect humanitarian and development budgets, we need to do more with less.



Evidence helps inform our decisions and anchors our innovation

What does the evidence tell us about the potential of (anticipatory) cash transfers?

Cash works to improve welfare outcomes

in low- and middle-income countries more generally

in humanitarian contexts

Providing financial support to families in advance of

extreme weather events can improve their resilience

and recovery.



Giving cash works

When low-income families receive cash with no strings attached, their lives improve in measurable ways.

Overview

Cash works



Evidence from over 100 studies of UCTs demonstrates their potential to meaningfully improve people's lives.



Recipients use the cash wisely.

[Evans et al., 2017; J-PAL, 2020;](#)



The benefits of UCTs can extend beyond the household.

[Haushofer & Shapiro, 2018; Egger et al., 2022,](#)

Cash without conditions lets people experiencing poverty make their own choices.



Evidence from over 100 studies of UCTs demonstrates their potential to meaningfully improve people's lives.

[\(Crosta et al, 2025\)](#)

Cash recipients report:

- Better food security
- Improved income and savings
- Increased spending
- Better well-being
- More likely to pay off debts
- Better employed
- More likely to enroll children in school



As a result of cash, well-being of individuals and families improves with some effects persisting for years

Design considerations

Both conditional and unconditional cash transfers are evidence-based options in policymakers' toolkits; which one to implement depends on the circumstances and the outcomes they are trying to achieve.

- With specific goals in mind, like improving school attendance or improving child health, conditional cash transfers can be an effective approach.
 - soft or hard conditions, depending on monitoring capacity
- If policymakers have broader policy goals, then unconditional cash transfers may be the right fit.
- In between : labelled cash transfers

Cash in Humanitarian Settings

Over 300 million people are currently in need of humanitarian assistance, driven by a record number of armed conflicts and weather-related disasters.



Cash and voucher assistance reduces families' food insecurity during humanitarian crises.



Cash gives families the power to decide what they need most.



Cash can improve more aspects of people's lives in humanitarian settings.

Beyond the lesson that 'cash works', how it is delivered also matters

- **DRC:** Both cash and vouchers increased food security and asset ownership, but cash gave households greater flexibility and was more cost-effective (Aker, 2017)
- **Niger:** Mobile cash transfers to women were not only more cost-effective than physical cash distribution, but also led to more diverse diets and their children eating more (Aker et al, 2016)
- **Afghanistan:** Digital payments to female-headed households improved food security and mental wellbeing, with no signs of funds being diverted to unintended groups (Callen et al, 2025)

Cash transfers can cushion negative effects of weather events and can partially reduce reliance on costly coping mechanisms

“Atencion a Crisis” in Nicaragua

A conditional cash transfer from the government helped households protect themselves against drought, leading to positive persistent impacts on child health, and household consumption, through facilitating income diversification

[Macours et al, 2012, 2022,](#)

Drought in Niger

In response to a devastating drought in Niger, faster disbursement of cash via mobile money mitigated the welfare cost of the shock.

[Aker, 2016](#)

Drought in Niger

A multi-year cash transfer program fostered resilience by facilitating savings and income smoothing. Small regular cash transfers raised household consumption. Drought-affected households experienced welfare gains exceeding the transfer amount.

[Premand and Stoeffler, 2022](#)

Response to Cyclone in Fiji

Top-up payments for households participating in cash transfer programmes following a sudden climate event

Households receiving transfers recovered more quickly than those that did not

[Mansur, 2017;](#)
[Ivaschenko, 2020](#)

Does the timing of assistance matter ?

Why the timing of assistance may matters for welfare in cases of severe weather events ?

- **Traditional emergency response:** Transfers to help households cope with shock once it occurred
- **Anticipatory action:** Providing liquidity before the shock can help households to adopt pre-emptive solutions and adjust livelihoods.
 - Diversify income sources ex-ante to reduce vulnerability to weather-related agricultural income shocks ([Macours, et al, 2022](#))
 - Providing resources when labor market returns to better nutrition are highest ([Behrman, 1993](#); [Banerjee and Duflo, 2007](#))
 - Greater mental scarcity as food insecurity increases ([Mani et al., 2013](#))
- **However: contexts matters!** early cash support may be suboptimal if households are unable to save or smooth their consumption throughout the crisis period.
 - Instead use regular and smaller cash transfers? Can serve to smooth consumption, but size may limit investment in durable goods or productive assets ([Crosta et al., 2025](#)).
- **While the effectiveness of cash transfer programs to protect against shocks is well documented**
 - **More evidence is needed** on the impact of varying the timing of cash transfers

Acting before disaster strikes

Providing quick financial
support to families in advance
of extreme weather events
can improve their resilience
and recovery.



Photo credit: Sk Hasan Ali, Shutterstock.com

Accumulating evidence:

Cash transfers are most helpful/at least as helpful

when they come before, rather than after, an emergency

Nepal: Providing cash transfers within days of a flood improved food security and psychological well-being more than traditional humanitarian aid delivered ~ 2 months following the climate shock ([Dunsch et al, 2025](#))

Niger: Researchers compared the benefits of cash transfers before the lean season, a more traditional response during the lean season, and a regular transfer after a drought. Families who received cash the earliest fared better early on. However, welfare effects converge after the lean season ([Pople et al, 2025](#))

Bangladesh: Families who received cash prior to floods had reduced asset loss, engaged in less costly borrowing, and improved recovery from floods compared to no assistance ([Pople et al, 2021](#))

Acting before repeated disasters strike again

Climate resilient agricultural
technologies and techniques,
can help protect against
recurring weather shocks



Photo credit: Sk Hasan Ali | Shutterstock.com

Insights from rigorous evidence on building farmers' resilience to climate change

Certain resilient **agricultural technologies and practices** help farmers maintain or increase yield, and maintain and increase profit, but others don't

Farmers are **more likely to take up** resilience-building agricultural technologies

- in seasons when they experience weather shocks because the **benefits are made evident**
- In contexts where there is a good understanding of their vulnerability to climate change

But **learning in agriculture can be complex and slow** given multidimensionality of decision making ([Laajaj and Macours, 2026](#))

Social assistance programs can complement resilience-building agricultural technologies:

- by helping farmers smooth consumption and avoid selling productive assets after experiencing a weather shock
- by bolstering farmers' resilience by enabling them to **pursue alternative sources of income**

Design considerations for anticipatory action interventions



Crucially rely on reliable forecast accuracy and timing

=> requires investment in forecasting models and early warning systems

New data sources offer potential for improved targeting

An emergency cash transfer programme in Togo found that mobile phone network data, analysed using machine learning algorithms trained to detect patterns of poverty, improved the targeting of assistance and enabled faster identification of those most in need

[Aiken, 2022](#)

Further learning on Anticipatory Action : Some open questions in need of rigorous causal (RCT)evidence

Role of messaging and credibility of information on forecasted shocks

- How to assure salience and trust in forecast information so that households' behavioral response reflect future shocks?

Protecting (agricultural) livelihoods versus diversifying livelihoods

- In light of increased frequency & recurring shocks, when and how to design interventions that protect existing livelihood strategies versus encourage income diversification?

Understanding general equilibrium effects of anticipatory action

- Markets and prices
- But also, for instance, in (semi-) pastoralist settings possible trade-offs between short-term livelihood protection versus natural resource pressures

Other open questions & need for further learning on Anticipatory Action

Improving forecasting

- How can forecasting be improved with machine learnings and artificial intelligence?
- How should forecast thresholds be set for triggering action?
- Can early action be applied to other crises such as heat waves, disease outbreaks, and migration?

Targeting

- What are the trade-offs between early assistance to fewer households and later, more targeted assistance to more households under budget constraints?
- How does targeting accuracy change across the disaster timeline, and how does this affect the effectiveness of anticipatory action?

Long terms impact questions

- Understand long-term impacts of anticipatory actions
- Can anticipatory agricultural support stabilize food systems across multiple seasons?
- Do households adopt more climate-resilient practices in the long term after exposure to anticipatory programs?

Cost-effectiveness of anticipatory action

- Investment in cost-data is necessary across organisations to understand the cost-effectiveness of anticipatory action
- How can cost-effectiveness information guide programmatic design?

Concluding thoughts

The stakes are enormous: Increased vulnerability in LMIC due to increased frequency and severity of weather, geopolitical and environmental shocks
=> calls for cost-effective solutions

Need for rigorous evidence to evaluate the promise of Anticipatory Action:

When does AA work?

How does AA work?

How to make AA work better?

What are the trade-offs?

Accumulating evidence: Cash transfers work. Transfers are more/at least as effective when they come before shocks hit

Many open questions on different types of AA interventions call for more rigorous causal studies & learning